

Top Technology Stories of 2024

Throughout 2024, we saw further development of artificial intelligence (AI) systems and new legal action brought against technology companies. Here is a look back at some of the biggest tech stories we covered in 2024.

AI continues to expand

During the year, companies continued developing and deploying new AI tools.

Among these were a new set of AI offerings announced by American software company Microsoft. Officials explained the new tools included “personal agents” designed to help users complete business activities with little or no human involvement.

Microsoft says it designed the agents to expand on so-called chatbots – AI tools that work by themselves to produce human-level writing or discussions. The company said it expects a full release of the agents sometime in 2025.

In September, technology company Apple announced it was launching several new iPhones equipped with special chips to support AI operations. Apple chief Tim Cook said the new models had been “designed for Apple Intelligence from the ground up.”

We reported in October about an effort by researchers to use AI to improve existing weather prediction models. One system works by combining past weather predictions with modern methods to provide the most complete picture of weather and climate data.

More warnings AI’s possible dangers

In California, three legislative measures were enacted to ban the use of AI tools to create false images and videos during election campaigns. One main goal was to fight deepfakes. These are pieces of video or audio created to make it appear that people in it are saying or doing things they never said or did. Deepfakes were used in several world election campaigns in 2024.

In May, an international gathering of major AI developers and top government officials in Seoul agreed on measures that aim to ensure that AI systems are safely built and deployed. Attendees from 16 different technology companies signed a promise to develop AI technology in ways that limit possible public harms.

US legal moves against tech companies

About one year ago, an American jury found that Google’s app store operates as an illegal monopoly. Then in August 2024, a federal judge ruled that Google had violated trade laws by

operating its search engine as a monopoly. The ruling accused Google of paying smartphone makers to ensure that its search engine was set as the default system on new devices.

As part of the case, the U.S. government proposed in November a series of measures to limit Google from anti-competition business activities. Google criticized the court's ruling as an example of government overreach. U.S. officials have long warned that TikTok presents national security concerns.

Earlier this month, video sharing service TikTok asked a U.S. appeals court to block a law requiring its Chinese parent, ByteDance, to divest itself of TikTok or face a U.S. ban. The request came after the same court had upheld a law forcing ByteDance to sell TikTok by January 19 or face the ban. Lawyers for ByteDance and TikTok are seeking to have the U.S. Supreme Court rule on the case.

Self-driving tech

In May, U.S.-based Aurora Innovation said it was preparing to launch a series of driverless trucks to transport goods on a major public highway. Company officials said it planned to begin the service in Texas, with 20 tractor-trailers transporting goods between Dallas and Houston. The company hopes to expand the service to thousands of tractor-trailers within three to four years.

Flying taxis

In October, the U.S. Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) announced it had issued final rules for operating air taxis. It also set training and approval requirements for pilots. The FAA said air taxis belong to a kind of aircraft known as Advanced Air Mobility (AAM) flyers. They generally operate on their own on electrical power, with vertical take-off and landing abilities.

FAA Administrator Mike Whitaker said such aircraft represent “the first new category of aircraft in nearly 80 years.” He added that the new rules are meant to mark the beginning of possible widespread AAM operations across the U.S. in the future.

I'm Bryan Lynn.

Bryan Lynn wrote this story for VOA Learning English.

Quiz - Top Technology Stories of 2024

Vocabulary

chip - n. แผ่นซิลิคอนขนาดเล็กมากที่บรรจุวงจรอิเล็กทรอนิกส์ (เช่น สำหรับคอมพิวเตอร์)

monopoly - n. การผูกขาด (การควบคุมอุปทานสินค้าหรือบริการทั้งหมดในพื้นที่หรือตลาดหนึ่งๆ อย่างสมบูรณ์)

default - adj. ค่าเริ่มต้น (สิ่งที่ดำรงอยู่หรือเกิดขึ้นตามปกติหากไม่มีการเปลี่ยนแปลง)

divest - v. ถอนการลงทุน, ขาย (โดยเฉพาะอย่างยิ่งธุรกิจหรือส่วนหนึ่งของธุรกิจ)

vertical - adj. แนวตั้ง (ชี้ตรงขึ้นไปจากพื้นผิว)

category - n. หมวดหมู่, ประเภท (กลุ่มคนหรือสิ่งของที่มีลักษณะคล้ายกัน)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the main focus of the article for the year 2024?

- A) Future predictions for AI advancements.
- B) A review of major technology developments and legal actions.
- C) The economic impact of technology companies.
- D) New regulations for internet privacy.

2. Which company announced new 'personal agents' designed to help users with business activities?

- A) Apple
- B) Google
- C) Microsoft
- D) Aurora Innovation

3. What is the relationship between Microsoft's new 'personal agents' and existing chatbots?

- A) They are intended to replace chatbots entirely.
- B) They are designed to expand on the capabilities of chatbots.
- C) They operate independently and are unrelated to chatbots.
- D) They are an earlier, less advanced version of chatbots.

4. What technological advancement did Apple announce in September?

- A) A new search engine with AI capabilities.
- B) New iPhones equipped with special chips to support AI operations.
- C) Personal agents for business use, similar to Microsoft's.
- D) A new system for improving weather predictions.

5. How are researchers attempting to improve weather prediction models using AI?

- A) By solely relying on new satellite imagery.
- B) By combining past weather predictions with modern methods.
- C) By developing completely new data collection sensors.
- D) By using AI to manually analyze historical climate data.

6. What was a main objective of the legislative measures enacted in California regarding AI?

- A) To promote the widespread adoption of AI tools in all sectors.
- B) To ban the use of AI in creating false images and videos during election campaigns.
- C) To establish a new regulatory body for AI development.
- D) To encourage international cooperation on AI ethics.

7. What is a 'deepfake' according to the article?

- A) A highly complex AI algorithm for data analysis.
- B) A piece of video or audio created to make people appear to say or do things they never said or did.
- C) An advanced form of a chatbot that can mimic human emotions.
- D) A new type of encryption used for securing online communications.

8. What was the key outcome of the international gathering of AI developers and government officials in Seoul?

- A) A complete ban on further AI research and development.
- B) An agreement on measures to ensure safe AI system development and deployment.
- C) The formation of a global AI monitoring agency.
- D) A resolution to limit AI's use to only scientific research.

9. What did a federal judge rule against Google in August 2024 regarding its search engine?

- A) Google's search engine was technologically outdated.
- B) Google had violated trade laws by operating its search engine as a monopoly.
- C) Google's data privacy policies were inadequate.
- D) Google had failed to meet innovation targets.

10. According to the ruling, how did Google maintain its search engine's dominant position?

- A) By offering superior user experience compared to competitors.
- B) By acquiring smaller search engine companies.
- C) By paying smartphone makers to set its search engine as the default system.
- D) By investing heavily in marketing and advertising.

11. How did Google respond to the court's ruling regarding its business practices?

- A) It immediately appealed the decision to the Supreme Court.
- B) It announced a restructuring of its search engine division.
- C) It criticized the ruling as an example of government overreach.

D) It agreed to implement the proposed measures without objection.

12. What was TikTok's legal action earlier this month concerning its operations in the U.S.?

A) It filed a lawsuit against Google for monopolistic practices.

B) It asked a U.S. appeals court to block a law requiring its parent company to divest it.

C) It sought permission to launch self-driving trucks in the U.S.

D) It challenged the FAA's new rules for air taxis.

13. What kind of service is Aurora Innovation preparing to launch in Texas?

A) A network of flying taxis between major cities.

B) A series of driverless trucks to transport goods on a public highway.

C) An AI-powered public transportation system.

D) A new app for managing supply chain logistics.

14. What did the U.S. Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) announce in October concerning Advanced Air Mobility (AAM) flyers?

A) A ban on all private drone operations.

B) New security protocols for commercial airlines.

C) Final rules for operating air taxis and pilot training requirements.

D) A partnership with Tesla for electric aircraft development.

15. According to FAA Administrator Mike Whitaker, what is the significance of air taxis?

A) They are a minor upgrade to existing helicopter technology.

B) They represent the first new category of aircraft in nearly 80 years.

C) They are exclusively for military and government use.

D) They are a short-term solution for urban congestion.